Scarron was heated, the cold seized on him, and when he reached the farther bank he found himself crippled.

Every means had been employed in vain to restore the use of his limbs. He had been subjected to a severe disciplinary course of medicine, at length he sent away all his doctors, declaring that he preferred the disease to the treatment, and came to Paris, where the fame of his wit had preceded him. There he had a chair made on his own plan, and one day, visiting Anne of Austria in this chair, she asked him, charmed as she was with his wit, if he did not wish for a title.

'Yes, your majesty, there is a title which I covet much,' replied Scarron.

'And what is that?'

'That of being *your* invalid,' answered Scarron.

So he was called the queen's invalid, with a pension of fifteen hundred francs.

From that lucky moment Scarron led a happy life, spending both income and principal. One day, however, an emissary of the cardinal's gave him to understand that he was wrong in receiving the coadjutor so often.

'And why?' asked Scarron; 'is he not a man of good birth?'

'Certainly.'

'Agreeable?'

'Undeniably.'

'Witty?'

'He has, unfortunately, too much wit.'

'Well, then, why do you wish me to give up seeing such a man?'

'Because he is an enemy.'

'Of whom?'

'Of the cardinal.'

'What?' answered Scarron, 'I continue to receive Monsieur Gilles Despreaux, who thinks ill of *me*, and you wish me to give up seeing the coadjutor, because he thinks ill of another man. Impossible!'

The conversation had rested there and Scarron, through sheer obstinacy, had seen Monsieur de Gondy only the more frequently.

Now, the very morning of which we speak was that of his quarter-day payment, and Scarron, as usual, had sent his servant to get his money at the

pension-office, but the man had returned and said that the government had no more money to give Monsieur Scarron.

It was on Thursday, the abbé's reception day; people went there in crowds. The cardinal's refusal to pay the pension was known about the town in half an hour and he was abused with wit and vehemence.

In the Rue Saint Honoré Athos fell in with two gentlemen whom he did not know, on horseback like himself, followed by a lackey like himself, and going in the same direction that he was. One of them, hat in hand, said to him:

'Would you believe it, monsieur? that contemptible Mazarin has stopped poor Scarron's pension.'

'That is unreasonable,' said Athos, saluting in his turn the two cavaliers. And they separated with courteous gestures.

'It happens well that we are going there this evening,' said Athos to the vicomte; 'we will pay our compliments to that poor man.'

'What, then, is this Monsieur Scarron, who thus puts all Paris in commotion? Is he some minister out of office?'

'Oh, no, not at all, vicomte,' Athos replied; 'he is simply a gentleman of great genius who has fallen into disgrace with the cardinal through having written certain verses against him.'

'Do gentlemen, then, make verses?' asked Raoul, naïvely, 'I thought it was derogatory.'

'So it is, my dear vicomte,' said Athos, laughing, 'to make bad ones; but to make good ones increases fame—witness Monsieur de Rotrou. Nevertheless,' he continued, in the tone of one who gives wholesome advice, 'I think it is better not to make them.'

'Then,' said Raoul, 'this Monsieur Scarron is a poet?'

'Yes; you are warned, vicomte. Consider well what you do in that house. Talk only by gestures, or rather always listen.'

'Yes, monsieur,' replied Raoul.

'You will see me talking with one of my friends, the Abbé d'Herblay, of whom you have often heard me speak.'

'I remember him, monsieur.'

'Come near to us from time to time, as if to speak; but do not speak, and do not listen. That little stratagem may serve to keep off interlopers.'

'Very well, monsieur; I will obey you at all points.'

Athos made two visits in Paris; at seven o'clock he and Raoul directed their steps to the Rue des Tournelles; it was stopped by porters, horses and footmen. Athos forced his way through and entered, followed by the young man. The first person that struck him on his entrance was Aramis, planted near a great chair on castors, very large, covered with a canopy of tapestry, under which there moved, enveloped in a quilt of brocade, a little face, youngish, very merry, somewhat pallid, whilst its eyes never ceased to express a sentiment at once lively, intellectual, and amiable. This was the Abbé Scarron, always laughing, joking, complimenting—yet suffering—and toying nervously with a small switch.

Around this kind of rolling tent pressed a crowd of gentlemen and ladies. The room was neatly, comfortably furnished. Large valances of silk, embroidered with flowers of gay colours, which were rather faded, fell from the wide windows; the fittings of the room were simple, but in excellent taste. Two well trained servingmen were in attendance on the company. On perceiving Athos, Aramis advanced toward him, took him by the hand and presented him to Scarron. Raoul remained silent, for he was not prepared for the dignity of the *bel esprit*.

After some minutes the door opened and a footman announced Mademoiselle Paulet.

Athos touched the shoulder of the vicomte.

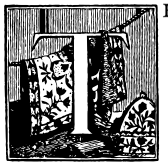
'Look at this lady, Raoul, she is an historic personage; it was to visit her King Henry IV was going when he was assassinated.'

Every one thronged around Mademoiselle Paulet, for she was always very much the fashion. She was a tall woman, with a slender figure and a forest of golden curls, such as Raphael was fond of and Titian has painted all his Magdalens with. This fawn-coloured hair, or, perhaps the sort of ascendancy which she had over other women, gave her the name of 'La Lionne.' Mademoiselle Paulet took her accustomed seat, but before sitting down, she cast, in all her queen-like grandeur, a look around the room, and her eyes rested on Raoul.

Athos smiled.

Chapter XXI

The Abbé Scarron



THERE was once in the Rue des Tournelles a house known by all the sedan chairmen and footmen of Paris, and yet, nevertheless, this house was neither that of a great lord nor of a rich man. There was neither dining, nor playing at cards, nor dancing in that house. Nevertheless, it was the rendezvous of the great world and all Paris went there. It was the abode of the little Abbé Scarron.

In the home of the witty abbé dwelt incessant laughter; there all the items of the day had their source and were so quickly transformed, misrepresented, metamorphosed, some into epigrams, some into falsehoods, that every one was anxious to pass an hour with little Scarron, listening to what he said, reporting it to others.

The diminutive Abbé Scarron, who, however, was an abbé only because he owned an abbey, and not because he was in orders, had formerly been one of the gayest prebendaries in the town of Mans, which he inhabited. On a day of the carnival he had taken a notion to provide an unusual entertainment for that good town, of which he was the life and soul. He had made his valet cover him with honey; then, opening a feather bed, he had rolled in it and had thus become the most grotesque fowl it is possible to imagine. He then began to visit his friends of both sexes, in that strange costume. At first he had been followed through astonishment, then with derisive shouts, then the porters had insulted him, then children had thrown stones at him, and finally he was obliged to run, to escape the missiles. As soon as he took to flight every one pursued him, until, pressed on all sides, Scarron found no way of escaping his escort, except by throwing himself into the river; but the water was icy cold.

'Madame,' answered the youth in his sweet voice, 'it seems to me that there is only *one* career for a gentleman—that of the army. I have been brought up by monsieur le comte with the intention, I believe, of making me a soldier; and he gave me reason to hope that at Paris he would present me to some one who would recommend me to the favour of the prince.'

'Yes, I understand it well. Personally, I am on bad terms with him, on account of the quarrels between Madame de Montbazon, my mother-in-law, and Madame de Longueville. But the Prince de Marsillac! Yes, indeed, that's the right thing. The Prince de Marsillac—my old friend—will recommend our young friend to Madame de Longueville, who will give him a letter to her brother, the prince, who loves her too tenderly not to do what she wishes immediately.'

'Well, that will do charmingly,' said the count; 'but may I beg that the greatest haste may be made, for I have reasons for wishing the vicomte not to sleep longer than to-morrow night in Paris!'

'Do you wish it known that you are interested about him, monsieur le comte?'

'Better for him in future that he should be supposed never to have seen me.'

'Oh, sir!' cried Raoul.

'You know, Bragelonne,' said Athos, 'I never speak without reflection.'

'Well, comte, I am going instantly,' interrupted the duchess, 'to send for the Prince de Marsillac, who is happily, in Paris just now. What are you going to do this evening?'

'We intend to visit the Abbé Scarron, for whom I have a letter of introduction and at whose house I expect to meet some of my friends.'

''Tis well; I will go there also, for a few minutes,' said the duchess; 'do not quit his *salon* until you have seen me.'

Athos bowed and prepared to leave.

'Well, monsieur le comte,' said the duchess, smiling, 'does one leave so solemnly his old friends?'

'Ah,' murmured Athos, kissing her hand, 'had I only sooner known that Marie Michon was so charming a creature!' And he withdrew, sighing.

Around this rolling tent pressed a crowd

'Mademoiselle Paulet has observed you, vicomte; go and bow to her; don't try to appear anything but what you are, a true country youth; on no account speak to her of Henry IV'

'When shall we two walk together?' Athos then said to Aramis.

'Presently—there are not a sufficient number of people here yet; we shall be remarked.'

At this moment the door opened and in walked the coadjutor.

At this name every one looked around, for his was already a very celebrated name. Athos did the same. He knew the Abbé de Gondy only by report.

He saw a little dark man, ill made and awkward with his hands in everything—except drawing a sword and firing a pistol—with something haughty and contemptuous in his face.

Scarron turned around toward him and came to meet him in his chair.

'Well,' said the coadjutor, on seeing him, 'you are in disgrace, then, abbé?'

This was the orthodox phrase. It had been said that evening a hundred times—and Scarron was at his hundredth *bon mot* on the subject; he was very nearly at the end of his humoristic tether, but one despairing effort saved him.

'Monsieur, the Cardinal Mazarin has been so kind as to think of me,' he said.

'But how can you continue to receive us?' asked the coadjutor; 'if your income is lessened I shall be obliged to make you a canon of Notre Dame.'

'Oh, no!' cried Scarron, 'I should compromise you too much.'

'Perhaps you have resources of which we are ignorant?'

'I shall borrow from the queen.'

'But her majesty has no property,' interposed Aramis.

At this moment the door opened and Madame de Chevreuse was announced. Every one arose. Scarron turned his chair toward the door, Raoul blushed, Athos made a sign to Aramis, who went and hid himself in the enclosure of a window.

In the midst of all the compliments that awaited her on her entrance, the duchess seemed to be looking for some one; at last she found out Raoul and her eyes sparkled; she perceived Athos and became thoughtful; she saw Aramis in the seclusion of the window and gave a start of surprise behind her fan.

'Apropos,' she said, as if to drive away thoughts that pursued her in spite of herself, 'how is poor Voiture, do you know, Scarron?'

his education and I have made him, I hope, an accomplished gentleman; but I am now obliged to return to the dangerous and wandering life of party faction. To-morrow I plunge into an adventurous affair in which I may be killed. Then it will devolve on you to push him on in that world where he is called on to occupy a place.'

'Rest assured,' cried the duchess, 'I shall do what I can. I have but little influence now, but all that I have shall most assuredly be his. As to his title and fortune— '

'As to that, madame, I have made over to him the estate of Bragelonne, my inheritance, which will give him ten thousand francs a year and the title of vicomte.'

'Upon my soul, monsieur,' said the duchess, 'you are a true nobleman! But I am eager to see our young vicomte. Where is he?'

'There, in the *salon*. I will have him come in, if you really wish it.'

Athos moved toward the door; the duchess held him back.

'Is he handsome?' she asked.

Athos smiled.

'He resembles his mother.'

So he opened the door and beckoned the young man in.

The duchess could not restrain a cry of joy on seeing so handsome a young cavalier, so far surpassing all that her maternal pride had been able to conceive.

'Vicomte, come here,' said Athos; 'the duchess permits you to kiss her hand.'

The youth approached with his charming smile and his head bare, and kneeling down, kissed the hand of the Duchess de Chevreuse.

'Sir,' he said, turning to Athos, 'was it not in compassion to my timidity that you told me that this lady was the Duchess de Chevreuse, and is she not the queen?'

'No, vicomte,' said Madame de Chevreuse, taking his hand and making him sit near her, while she looked at him with eyes sparkling with pleasure; 'no, unhappily, I am not the queen. If I were I should do for you at once the most that you deserve. But let us see; whatever I may be,' she added, hardly restraining herself from kissing that pure brow, 'let us see what profession you wish to follow.'

Athos, standing, looked at them both with indescribable pleasure.

and recognised that little Kitty whom our friend Aramis had placed with her. In that way I discovered that the charming traveller was— '

'Marie Michon!' said Madame de Chevreuse, hastily.

'Marie Michon,' continued Athos. 'Then I went out of the house; I proceeded to the stable and found my horse saddled and my lackey ready. We set forth on our journey.'

'And have you never revisited that village?' eagerly asked Madame de Chevreuse.

'A year after, madame.'

'Well?'

'I wanted to see the good curé again. I found him much preoccupied with an event that he could not at all comprehend. A week before he had received, in a cradle, a beautiful little boy three months old, with a purse filled with gold and a note containing these simple words: "11 October, 1633."'

'It was the date of that strange adventure,' interrupted Madame de Chevreuse.

'Yes, but he couldn't understand what it meant, for he had spent that night with a dying person and Marie Michon had left his house before his return.'

'You must know, monsieur, that Marie Michon, when she returned to France in 1643, immediately sought for information about that child; as a fugitive she could not take care of it, but on her return she wished to have it near her.'

'And what said the abbé?' asked Athos.

'That a nobleman whom he did not know had wished to take charge of it, had answered for its future, and had taken it away.'

'That was true.'

'Ah! I see! That nobleman was you; it was his father!'

'Hush! do not speak so loud, madame; he is there.'

'He is there! my son! the son of Marie Michon! But I must see him instantly.'

'Take care, madame,' said Athos, 'for he knows neither his father nor his mother.'

'You have kept the secret! you have brought him to see me, thinking to make me happy. Oh, thanks! sir, thanks!' cried Madame de Chevreuse, seizing his hand and trying to put it to her lips; 'you have a noble heart.'

'I bring him to you, madame,' said Athos, withdrawing his hand, 'hoping that in your turn you will do something for him; till now I have watched over

'What, is Monsieur Voiture ill?' inquired a gentleman who had spoken to Athos in the Rue Saint Honoré; 'what is the matter with him?'

'He was acting, but forgot to take the precaution to have a change of linen ready after the performance,' said the coadjutor, 'so he took cold and is about to die.'

'Is he then so ill, dear Voiture?' asked Aramis, half hidden by the window curtain.

'Die!' cried Mademoiselle Paulet, bitterly, '*he!* Why, he is surrounded by sultanas, like a Turk. Madame de Saintot has hastened to him with broth; La Renaudot warms his sheets; the Marquise de Rambouillet sends him his *tisanes*.'

'You don't like him, my dear Parthénie,' said Scarron.

'What an injustice, my dear invalid! I hate him so little that I should be delighted to order masses for the repose of his soul.'

'You are not called "Lionne" for nothing,' observed Madame de Chevreuse, 'your teeth are terrible.'

'You are unjust to a great poet, it seems to me,' Raoul ventured to say.

'A great poet! come, one may easily see, vicomte, that you are lately from the provinces and have never so much as seen him. A great poet! he is scarcely five feet high.'

'Bravo bravo!' cried a tall man with an enormous moustache and a long rapier, 'bravo, fair Paulet, it is high time to put little Voiture in his right place. For my part, I always thought his poetry detestable, and I think I know *something* about poetry.'

'Who is this officer,' inquired Raoul of Athos, 'who is speaking?'

'Monsieur de Scudéry, the author of "Clélie," and of "Le Grand Cyrus," which were composed partly by him and partly by his sister, who is now talking to that pretty person yonder, near Monsieur Scarron.'

Raoul turned and saw two faces just arrived. One was perfectly charming, delicate, pensive, shaded by beautiful dark hair, and eyes soft as velvet, like those lovely flowers, the heartsease, in which shine out the golden petals. The other, of mature age, seemed to have the former one under her charge, and was cold, dry and yellow—the true type of a duenna or a devotee.

Raoul resolved not to quit the room without having spoken to the beautiful girl with the soft eyes, who by a strange fancy, although she bore no resemb-

lance, reminded him of his poor little Louise, whom he had left in the Château de la Vallière and whom, in the midst of all the party, he had never for one moment quite forgotten. Meantime Aramis had drawn near to the coadjutor, who, smiling all the while, contrived to drop some words into his ear. Aramis, notwithstanding his self-control, could not refrain from a slight movement of surprise.

'Laugh, then,' said Monsieur de Retz; 'they are looking at us.' And leaving Aramis he went to talk with Madame de Chevreuse, who was in the midst of a large group.

Aramis affected a laugh, to divert the attention of certain curious listeners, and perceiving that Athos had betaken himself to the embrasure of a window and remained there, he proceeded to join him, throwing out a few words carelessly as he moved through the room.

As soon as the two friends met they began a conversation which was emphasized by frequent gesticulation.

Raoul then approached them as Athos had directed him to do.

''Tis a rondeau by Monsieur Voiture that monsieur l'abbé is repeating to me.' said Athos in a loud voice, 'and I confess I think it incomparable.'

Raoul stayed only a few minutes near them and then mingled with the group round Madame de Chevreuse.

'Well, then?' asked Athos, in a low tone.

'It is to be to-morrow,' said Aramis hastily.

'At what time?'

'Six o'clock.'

'Where?'

'At Saint Mandé.'

'Who told you?'

'The Count de Rochefort.'

Some one drew near.

'And then philosophic ideas are wholly wanting in Voiture's works, but I am of the same opinion as the coadjutor—he is a poet, a true poet.' Aramis spoke so as to be heard by everybody.

'And I, too,' murmured the young lady with the velvet eyes. 'I have the misfortune also to admire his poetry exceedingly.'

'Really, monsieur,' said Madame de Chevreuse, 'unless you are the devil in person I don't know how you could become acquainted with all these details.'

'A charming woman was that Marie Michon,' resumed Athos, 'one of those wild creatures who are constantly conceiving the strangest ideas. Now, thinking that her host was a priest, that coquette took it into her head that it would be a happy souvenir for her old age, among the many happy souvenirs she already possessed, if she could win that of having damned an abbé.'

'Count,' said the duchess, 'upon my word, you frighten me.'

'Alas!' continued Athos, 'the poor abbé was not a St Ambroise, and I repeat, Marie Michon was an adorable creature.'

'Monsieur!' cried the duchess, seizing Athos's hands, 'tell me this moment how you know all these details, or I will send to the convent of the Vieux Augustins for a monk to come and exorcise you.'

Athos laughed. 'Nothing is easier, madame. A cavalier, charged with an important mission, had come an hour before your arrival, seeking hospitality, at the very moment that the curé, summoned to the bedside of a dying person, left not only his house but the village, for the entire night. The priest having all confidence in his guest, who, besides, was a nobleman, had left to him his house, his supper and his chamber. And therefore Marie came seeking hospitality from the guest of the good abbé and not from the good abbé himself.'

'And that cavalier, that guest, that nobleman who arrived before she came?'

'It was I, the Comte de la Fère,' said Athos, rising and bowing respectfully to the Duchess de Chevreuse.

The duchess remained a moment stupefied; then, suddenly bursting into laughter:

'Ah! upon my word,' said she, 'it is very droll, and that mad Marie Michon fared better than she expected. Sit down, dear count, and go on with your story.'

'At this point I have to accuse myself of a fault, madame. I have told you that I was travelling on an important mission. At daybreak I left the chamber without noise, leaving my charming companion asleep. In the front room the follower was also still asleep, her head leaning back on the chair, in all respects worthy of her mistress. Her pretty face arrested my attention; I approached

'The journey of that day had been long and wearing; it was a cold day, the eleventh of October, there was no inn or château in the village and the homes of the peasants were poor and unattractive. Marie Michon was a very aristocratic person; like her sister the queen, she had been accustomed to pleasing perfumes and fine linen; she resolved, therefore, to seek hospitality of the priest.'

Athos paused.

'Oh, continue!' said the duchess. 'I have told you that I am prepared for anything.'

'The two travellers knocked at the door. It was late; the priest, who had gone to bed, cried out to them to come in. They entered, for the door was not locked—there is much confidence among villagers. A lamp burned in the chamber occupied by the priest. Marie Michon, who made the most charming cavalier in the world, pushed open the door, put her head in and asked for hospitality. "Willingly, my young cavalier," said the priest, "if you will be content with the remains of my supper and with half my chamber."

The two travellers consulted for a moment. The priest heard a burst of laughter and then the master, or rather, the mistress, replied: "Thank you, monsieur le curé, I accept." "Sup, then, and make as little noise as possible," said the priest, "for I, too, have been on the go all day and shall not be sorry to sleep to-night."'

Madame de Chevreuse evidently went from surprise to astonishment, and from astonishment to stupefaction. Her face, as she looked at Athos, had taken on an expression that cannot be described. It could be seen that she had wished to speak, but she had remained silent through fear of losing one of her companion's words.

'What happened then?' she asked.

'Then?' said Athos. 'Ah, I have come now to what is most difficult.'

'Speak, speak! One can say anything to me. Besides, it doesn't concern me; it relates to Mademoiselle Marie Michon.'

'Ah, that is true,' said Athos. 'Well, then, Marie Michon had supper with her follower, and then, in accordance with the permission given her, she entered the chamber of her host, Kitty meanwhile taking possession of an armchair in the room first entered, where they had taken their supper.'

'Monsieur Scarron, do me the honour,' said Raoul, blushing, 'to tell me the name of that young lady whose opinion seems so different from that of others of the company.'

'Ah! my young vicomte,' replied Scarron, 'I suppose you wish to propose to her an alliance offensive and defensive.'

Raoul blushed again.

'You asked the name of that young lady. She is called the fair Indian.'

'Excuse me, sir,' returned Raoul, blushing still more deeply, 'I know no more than I did before. Alas! I am from the country.'

'Which means that you know very little about the nonsense which here flows down our streets. So much the better, young man! so much the better! Don't try to understand it—you will only lose your time.'

'You forgive me, then, sir,' said Raoul, 'and you will deign to tell me who is the person that you call the young Indian?'

'Certainly; one of the most charming persons that lives—Mademoiselle Frances d'Aubigné.'

'Does she belong to the family of the celebrated Agrippa, the friend of Henry IV?'

'His granddaughter. She comes from Martinique, so I call her the beautiful Indian.'

Raoul looked surprised and his eyes met those of the young lady, who smiled.

The company went on speaking of the poet Voiture.

'Monsieur,' said Mademoiselle d'Aubigné to Scarron, as if she wished to join in the conversation he was engaged in with Raoul, 'do you not admire Monsieur Voiture's friends? Listen how they pull him to pieces even whilst they praise him; one takes away from him all claim to good sense, another robs him of his poetry, a third of his originality, another of his humour, another of his independence of character, a sixth—but, good heavens! what will they *leave* him? as Mademoiselle de Scudéry remarks.'

Scarron and Raoul laughed. The fair Indian, astonished at the sensation her observation produced, looked down and resumed her air of naïveté.

Athos, still within the inclosure of the window, watched this scene with a smile of disdain on his lips.

'Tell the Comte de la Fère to come to me,' said Madame de Chevreuse, 'I want to speak to him.'

'And I,' said the coadjutor, 'want it to be thought that I do *not* speak to him. I admire, I love him—for I know his former adventures—but I shall not speak to him until the day after to-morrow.'

'And why day after to-morrow?' asked Madame de Chevreuse.

'You will know that to-morrow evening,' said the coadjutor, smiling.

'Really, my dear Gondy,' said the duchess, 'you remind one of the Apocalypse. Monsieur d'Herblay,' she added, turning toward Aramis, 'will you be my servant once more this evening?'

'How can you doubt it?' replied Aramis; 'this evening, to-morrow, always; command me.'

'I will, then. Go and look for the Comte de la Fère; I wish to speak with him.'

Aramis found Athos and brought him.

'Monsieur le comte,' said the duchess, giving him a letter, 'here is what I promised you; our young friend will be extremely well received.'

'Madame, he is very happy in owing any obligation to you.'

'You have no reason to envy him on that score, for I owe to you the pleasure of knowing him,' replied the witty woman, with a smile which recalled Marie Michon to Aramis and to Athos.

As she uttered that *bon mot*, she arose and asked for her carriage. Mademoiselle Paulet had already gone; Mademoiselle de Scudéry was going.

'Vicomte,' said Athos to Raoul, 'follow the duchess; beg her to do you the favour to take your arm in going downstairs, and thank her as you descend.'

The fair Indian approached Scarron.

'You are going already?' he said.

'One of the last, as you see; if you hear anything of Monsieur Voiture, be so kind as to send me word to-morrow.'

'Oh!' said Scarron, 'he may die now.'

'Why?' asked the young girl with the velvet eyes.

'Certainly; his panegyric has been uttered.'

They parted, laughing, she turning back to gaze at the poor paralytic man with interest, he looking after her with eyes of love.

'Alas!' said Madame de Chevreuse, with a slight sigh and a little movement of her eyebrows that was peculiarly her own, 'since that time everything has changed.'

'And the queen had reason for her affection, for Marie was devoted to her—devoted to that degree that she served her as medium of intercourse with her brother, the king of Spain.'

'Which,' interrupted the duchess, 'is now brought up against her as a great crime.'

'And therefore,' continued Athos, 'the cardinal—the true cardinal, the other one—determined one fine morning to arrest poor Marie Michon and send her to the Château de Loches. Fortunately the affair was not managed so secretly but that it became known to the queen. The case had been provided for: if Marie Michon should be threatened with any danger the queen was to send her a prayer-book bound in green velvet.'

'That is true, monsieur, you are well informed.'

'One morning the green book was brought to her by the Prince de Marsillac. There was no time to lose. Happily Marie and a follower of hers named Kitty could disguise themselves admirably in men's clothes. The prince procured for Marie Michon the dress of a cavalier and for Kitty that of a lackey; he sent them two excellent horses, and the fugitives went out hastily from Tours, shaping their course toward Spain, trembling at the least noise, following unfrequented roads, and asking for hospitality when they found themselves where there was no inn.'

'Why, really, it was all exactly as you say!' cried Madame de Chevreuse, clapping her hands. 'It would indeed be strange if— ' she checked herself.

'If I should follow the two fugitives to the end of their journey?' said Athos. 'No, madame, I will not thus waste your time. We will accompany them only to a little village in Limousin, lying between Tulle and Angoulême—a little village called Roche-l'Abeille.'

Madame de Chevreuse uttered a cry of surprise, and looked at Athos with an expression of astonishment that made the old musketeer smile.

'Wait, madame,' continued Athos, 'what remains for me to tell you is even more strange than what I have narrated.'

'Monsieur,' said Madame de Chevreuse, 'I believe you are a sorcerer; I am prepared for anything. But really—No matter, go on.'

He stopped short.

'And Aramis,' said the duchess, quickly.

'And Aramis; I see you have not forgotten the name.'

'No,' she said; 'poor Aramis; a charming man, elegant, discreet, and a writer of poetical verses. I am afraid he has turned out ill,' she added.

'He has; he is an abbé.'

'Ah, what a misfortune!' exclaimed the duchess, playing carelessly with her fan. 'Indeed, sir, I thank you; you have recalled one of the most agreeable recollections of my youth.'

'Will you permit me, then, to recall another to you?'

'Relating to him?'

'Yes and no.'

'Faith!' said Madame de Chevreuse, 'say on. With a man like you I fear nothing.'

Athos bowed. 'Aramis,' he continued, 'was intimate with a young needlewoman from Tours, a cousin of his, named Marie Michon.'

'Ah, I knew her!' cried the duchess. 'It was to her he wrote from the siege of Rochelle, to warn her of a plot against the Duke of Buckingham.'

'Exactly so; will you allow me to speak to you of her?'

'If,' replied the duchess, with a meaning look, 'you do not say too much against her.'

'I should be ungrateful,' said Athos, 'and I regard ingratitude, not as a fault or a crime, but as a vice, which is much worse.'

'You ungrateful to Marie Michon, monsieur?' said Madame de Chevreuse, trying to read in Athos's eyes. 'But how can that be? You never knew her.'

'Eh, madame, who knows?' said Athos. 'There is a popular proverb to the effect that it is only mountains that never meet; and popular proverbs contain sometimes a wonderful amount of truth.'

'Oh, go on, monsieur, go on!' said Madame de Chevreuse eagerly; 'you can't imagine how much this conversation interests me.'

'You encourage me,' said Athos, 'I will continue, then. That cousin of Aramis, that Marie Michon, that needlewoman, notwithstanding her low condition, had acquaintances in the highest rank; she called the grandest ladies of the court her friend, and the queen—proud as she is, in her double character as Austrian and as Spaniard—called her her sister.'

One by one the several groups broke up. Scarron seemed not to observe that certain of his guests had talked mysteriously, that letters had passed from hand to hand and that the assembly had seemed to have a secret purpose quite apart from the literary discussion carried on with so much ostentation. What was all that to Scarron? At his house rebellion could be planned with impunity, for, as we have said, since that morning he had ceased to be 'the queen's invalid.'

As to Raoul, he had attended the duchess to her carriage, where, as she took her seat, she gave him her hand to kiss; then, by one of those wild caprices which made her so adorable and at the same time so dangerous, she had suddenly put her arm around his neck and kissed his forehead, saying:

'Vicomte, may my good wishes and this kiss bring you good fortune!'

Then she had pushed him away and directed the coachman to stop at the Hotel de Luynes. The carriage had started, Madame de Chevreuse had made a parting gesture to the young man, and Raoul had returned in a state of stupefaction.

Athos surmised what had taken place and smiled. 'Come, vicomte,' he said, 'it is time for you to go to bed; you will start in the morning for the army of monsieur le prince. Sleep well your last night as citizen.'

'I am to be a soldier then?' said the young man. 'Oh, monsieur, I thank you with all my heart.'

'Adieu, count,' said the Abbé d'Herblay; 'I return to my convent.'

'Adieu, abbé,' said the coadjutor, 'I am to preach to-morrow and have twenty texts to examine this evening.'

'Adieu, gentlemen,' said the count; 'I am going to sleep twenty-four hours; I am just falling down with fatigue.'

The three men saluted one another, whilst exchanging a last look.

Scarron followed their movements with a glance from the corner of his eye.

'Not one of them will do as he says,' he murmured, with his little monkey smile; 'but they may do as they please, the brave gentlemen! Who knows if they will not manage to restore to me my pension? They can move their arms, they can, and that is much. Alas, I have only my tongue, but I will try to show that it is good for something. Ho, there, Champenois! here, it is eleven o'clock. Come and roll me to bed. Really, that Demoiselle d'Aubigné is very charming!'

So the invalid disappeared soon afterward and went into his sleeping-room; and one by one the lights in the *salon* of the Rue des Tournelles were extinguished.

'I grant it, monsieur,' replied Madame de Chevreuse with her most gracious smile.

'But that is not all, madame. Oh, I am very presuming, I am aware. The interview for which I ask is of us two alone, and I very earnestly wish that it may not be interrupted.'

'I am not at home to any one,' said the Duchess de Chevreuse to the footman. 'You may go.'

The footman went out.

There ensued a brief silence, during which these two persons, who at first sight recognised each other so clearly as of noble race, examined each other without embarrassment on either side.

The duchess was the first to speak.

'Well, sir, I am waiting with impatience to hear what you wish to say to me.'

'And I, madame,' replied Athos, 'am looking with admiration.'

'Sir,' said Madame de Chevreuse, 'you must excuse me, but I long to know to whom I am talking. You belong to the court, doubtless, yet I have never seen you at court. Have you, by any chance, been in the Bastille?'

'No, madame, I have not; but very likely I am on the road to it.'

'Ah! then tell me who you are, and get along with you upon your journey,' replied the duchess, with the gayety which made her so charming, 'for I am sufficiently in bad odour already, without compromising myself still more.'

'Who I am, madame? My name has been mentioned to you—the Comte de la Fère; you do not know that name. I once bore another, which you knew, but you have certainly forgotten it.'

'Tell it me, sir.'

'Formerly,' said the count, 'I was Athos.'

Madame de Chevreuse looked astonished. The name was not wholly forgotten, but mixed up and confused with ancient recollections.

'Athos?' said she; 'wait a moment.'

And she placed her hands on her brow, as if to force the fugitive ideas it contained to concentration in a moment.

'Shall I help you, madame?' asked Athos.

'Yes, do,' said the duchess.

'This Athos was connected with three young musketeers, named Porthos, D'Artagnan, and— '